

PAKISTAN'S FOREIGN POLICY: A COMPREHENSIVE FRAMEWORK

I. FOUNDATIONAL CONCEPTS

A. What is Foreign Policy?

Definition: Foreign policy is how a country uses different strategies to guide its relationships with other countries and international organizations. It encompasses a wide range of objectives, including:

- Defense and security
- Economic benefits
- Humanitarian assistance
- Diplomatic engagement

Also defined as: The set of strategies and actions a state employs in its interactions with other states, unions, and international entities.

B. Guiding Principles of Pakistan's Foreign Policy

From the Constitution of Pakistan (Article 40)

The State shall endeavor to:

1. Preserve and strengthen fraternal relations among Muslim countries based on Islamic unity
2. Support the common interests of the peoples of Asia, Africa, and Latin America
3. Promote international peace and security
4. Foster goodwill and friendly relations among all nations
5. Encourage the settlement of international disputes by peaceful means

From Quaid-e-Azam Muhammad Ali Jinnah

"Our object should be peace within and peace without. We want to live peacefully and maintain cordial, friendly relations with our immediate neighbours and with the world at large."

"Our foreign policy is one of friendliness and goodwill towards the nations of the world. We do not cherish aggressive designs against any country or nation... and are prepared to make our utmost contribution to the promotion of peace and prosperity."

"Pakistan will never be found lacking in extending its material and moral support to the oppressed and suppressed peoples of the world, and in upholding the principles of the United Nations Charter."

C. Core Objectives of Pakistan's Foreign Policy

1. Friendly and cordial relationship with the People's Republic of China
2. Close relations with the United States (tactical and strategic)
3. Better economic and political ties with Muslim countries
4. Policy of Non-Alignment in world affairs (periodically)
5. Security – particularly against India
6. Economic development and geoeconomic leverage

II. DETERMINANTS OF PAKISTAN'S FOREIGN POLICY

A. Internal Determinants

- Political stability/instability
- Economic strength or weakness
- National consensus on foreign policy issues
- Quality of leadership
- Domestic public opinion
- Security threats perception
- Nuclear capability

B. External Determinants

- Geostrategic location
- Behavior of major powers (USA, China, Russia)
- Regional dynamics (India, Afghanistan, Iran)
- International organizations (UN, OIC, SCO, ECO)
- Global power rivalries (Cold War, Post-Cold War, emerging multipolarity)

C. Constitutional & Ideological Determinants

- Islam as state religion (96%+ Muslim population)
- Article 40 principles
- Muslim brotherhood as national DNA
- Protection of Muslim communities worldwide (Kashmir, Palestine, Rohingya, etc.)

III. GEOSTRATEGIC IMPORTANCE OF PAKISTAN

A. Geographical Position

Pakistan lies at the intersection of South Asia, Central Asia, and the Middle East – a geostrategic nexus.

B. External Borders & Neighbors

Border	Direction	Significance
India	East	Long, historically significant border; Kashmir dispute; LoC hotspot
Afghanistan	Northwest	Durand Line (disputed); porous mountainous border; security & trade challenges

Iran	West	Pakistan-Iran barrier; cultural & trade ties; 928 km border
China	Northeast	Karakoram Highway; all-weather strategic relationship
Arabian Sea	South	Access to sea trade; Karachi & Gwadar ports; warm waters year-round

C. Geopolitical Significance

1. Bridge between South Asia and Central Asia – connects oil-rich Middle East with energy-hungry South/East Asia
2. Balancing power dynamics – shares borders with China, India, Afghanistan, Iran
3. Access to Arabian Sea – crucial sea trade routes, naval capabilities
4. Proximity to major powers – at the heart of several regional power dynamics

D. Economic Significance

1. Trade and Energy Corridor – vital transit country
2. Agriculture and Resource Potential – Indus River System supports one of world's largest irrigation networks

E. Security Significance

1. Counterterrorism Efforts – frontline state
2. Nuclear Arsenal – only Muslim nuclear state; "Islamic Bomb" concept

F. Geopolitical Buffer Zone

- Historically served as a buffer state during Cold War (between Soviet influence and Western-aligned states)

- Acts as a frontline state in fight against terrorism (post-9/11)

G. Cultural and Historical Crossroads

- Historically a passageway for invading empires, traders, cultural exchanges (Alexander the Great, Mughals, Silk Road)
- Rich cultural heritage and diverse population shaped by centuries of movement

IV. SIX IMPORTANT PHASES OF PAKISTAN'S FOREIGN POLICY

Phase 1: Era of Neutrality (1947-1953)

Characteristics:

- Non-aligned years – Pakistan tried to maintain neutrality in Cold War
- Both USA and USSR invited Pakistan for support
- Pakistan beset with internal tasks: economic, political, religious problems
- Not in position to assume important international role

Problems Faced During This Period:

1. Hostile relations with India – 1948 war on Kashmir; UN resolution for plebiscite refused by India
2. Dispute over division of assets and river water distribution
3. Refugee problem and weak administrative/economic position
4. Afghan hostility – objected to Pakistan's UN membership; Pakhtunistan issue; refusal to accept Durand Line (1893 agreement reaffirmed in 1919)

Four Security Options Considered:

1. Remain neutral
2. Rely on Muslim countries (most still under colonial subjugation)
3. Join Soviet bloc
4. Join Western alliance system

Why Pakistan Chose Western Alliance:

1. US offered alliance membership to contain communism – Pakistan hoped for economic & military aid
2. Pakistani elite under Western influence; pro-West lobby strong; ideologically closer to US than USSR

Phase 2: Era of Alliances (1954-1962)

Key Actions:

- Joined SEATO (South East Asian Treaty Organization) in 1954
- Joined CENTO (Central Treaty Organization) in 1955
- Signed Defence Pact with US in 1959 – US guaranteed security in event of communist attack

Consequences:

- Pakistan termed as "US protege"
- PM Husain Shaheed Suhrawardy declared Pakistan "the most allied ally" of US
- Received substantial economic and military assistance
- Modernized military with Western equipment

Failures:

- Could not achieve main objective: security against India
- US did not pressure India on Kashmir plebiscite
- Offended India, Afghanistan, Soviet Union, Egypt

Events Forcing Reconsideration:

1. U-2 Incident (1960) – Soviet threat to wipe out Peshawar; American bases created embarrassment
2. Sino-Indo Border War (1962) – US massive military support to India despite Pakistan's protests
3. Detente (post-1962) – Cold War thawed; CENTO/SEATO became legacies; many countries delinked from superpower rivalry

Cost of Alliances:

- Isolated Pakistan from major Arab nations (except Iraq kept distance)

- Suez Crisis (1956) – Pakistan's support of British/French further strained Arab relations
- Earned ill will of many countries
- Pushed Pakistan heavily under US influence

Positive During This Period:

- Friendship with Turkey and Iran continued to grow (common pro-Western policies)
- Consistently supported Palestinian cause in international forums

Phase 3: Era of Bilateralism (1963-1978)

Definition: Conduct of relations between states maintaining equidistance from all superpowers – no tilt towards any specific power.

Key Developments:

- Lessened dependence on Western alliance system
- Developed close and cordial relations with China as alternative support against India
- 1965 Indo-Pakistan war – US adopted even-handed policy, suspended military assistance to both countries
- Responded to Soviet gestures of friendship
- Relations with Soviet Union improved considerably
- Moscow mediated Tashkent Agreement (January 1966) after 1965 war
- Turned to Third World and Middle East countries

Z.A. Bhutto Era (1971-1977):

- Took tour of 20 Muslim countries – "mission of renaissance of relations with Muslim world"
- Withdrew from Commonwealth and SEATO
- Recognized Socialist governments of North Korea and North Vietnam
- Extended total support for Arabs during Ramadan war (1973) against Israel
- Hosted Second Islamic Summit Conference in Lahore (1974)

Regional Cooperation:

- Formed Regional Cooperation for Development (RCD) in 1964 with Iran and Turkey
- Cultivated close relations with Saudi Arabia and Jordan

US Relations During This Phase:

- Except Nixon administration's sympathetic policy during 1971 war, relations not as cordial as 1950s-60s
- US suspended military aid twice: 1965 and 1971 wars

Advantages of Bilateralism:

- Increasing economic and political relations with Third World and Socialist countries

Phase 4: Era of Non-Alignment (1979-1989)

Background Events:

- Iranian Revolution (1979) – US influence liquidated; Iran withdrew from CENTO
- CENTO became ineffective
- Pakistan quit CENTO after Iran's withdrawal

Pakistan Joins NAM (Havana Summit, September 1979):

Three Reasons:

1. Changing geo-political situation in South-West Asia – Marxist revolution in Afghanistan (April 1978); Islamic revolution in Iran (February 1979)
2. Did not want to remain cut off from Third World mainstream politics – hoped for recognition and prestige
3. Internal political groups demanded withdrawal from Western alliances

Soviet Invasion of Afghanistan (1979):

- Dramatically changed situation
- US reoriented relations with Pakistan
- While maintaining NAM membership, Pakistan signed major aid packages:

US: \$3.2 billion (1982)

• \$4.02 billion (1986)

- US did not object to Pakistan's nuclear programme – it received a big boost

Main Objectives During This Period:

1. Friendly relations with China
2. Close relations with United States
3. Better economic/political ties with Muslim countries
4. Non-Alignment in world affairs
5. Security

Phase 5: Era of Post-Cold War (1990 – September 11, 2001)

Collapse of Cold War (1990-1991) Due To:

1. Gulf crisis and Gulf war – US-led coalition supremacy; UN resolutions without Moscow/Beijing resistance
2. Dismantling of Warsaw Pact and Soviet disunion – 15 new sovereign states (6 Muslim, 9 non-Muslim)

New US Assertiveness On:

- Nuclear proliferation in developing countries
- Action against Libya
- Economic concessions from Japan/Western Europe
- Break-up of Yugoslavia
- Inability of developing countries to seek justice
- Western intervention in internal affairs of weak states

Pakistan's Challenges:

- Lost precious time adjusting to new realities
- Isolated, pressured to roll back nuclear programme
- Threatened with "terrorist tag"
- Silenced on Kashmir
- Abandoned in Afghanistan
- Viewed with suspicion in Arab and Islamic world

Key Events:

- May 18 & 30, 1998: Pakistan conducted nuclear tests at Chaghi Hills in response to Indian tests
- US clamped economic & military sanctions under Pressler Amendment – widened conventional gap with India
- Intensification of freedom movement in occupied Kashmir – massive Indian troop deployment
- Nawaz Sharif's initiative for bilateral dialogue with India
- Kargil crisis

Phase 6: Era of Global Anti-Terrorism (September 11, 2001 – Present)

Post-9/11 Dilemmas:

Pakistan faced US ultimatums to:

1. Discard Taliban
2. Discard Islamic Jihad
3. Discard Islamic fundamentalists
4. Become accomplice in US military intervention in Afghanistan – or face consequences

Pakistan's Decision:

- Boldly joined international coalition against war on terrorism
- Became frontline state in this fight

Key Events:

- November 2001: US-led force removed Taliban from power; Karzai government installed in Kabul
- Pakistan provided bases for military operations against former ally Taliban
- March-April 2003: US/Britain invaded Iraq, dislodged Saddam regime
- Presidents Musharraf, Zardari, and later governments fully supported US

Impact:

- Positive impact on Pakistan's standing in international community
- Earned appreciation from international community

Critical Analysis (Post-2011 Reflection):

- Foreign policy must be rooted in domestic base: political stability, national consensus, sound economy, effective deterrence, quality of leadership
- Relations with distant "godfathers" no substitute for regional bonds
- Pakistan's Taliban policy had isolated country within entire region
- Countries deflect pressures through skillful diplomacy – "traditional diplomacy" insufficient
- Pakistan needs to look beyond American connection (more tactical than strategic)
- Must learn from India's broadened diplomatic reach (IBSA, bridges with Iran, China, Afghanistan, Tajikistan, UAE)
- Effective foreign policy requires domestic stability and national consensus

V. PAKISTAN'S RELATIONS WITH GREAT POWERS

A. Relations with the United States of America

Historical Overview:

- Strong economic and military ties but plagued by periods of mistrust and antagonism

Key Phases:

Period	Nature of Relationship
Cold War early years	Instrumental in SEATO to contain Soviet expansion
1965 War	US suspended military assistance to both India & Pakistan – no preferential treatment

1975	Arms sales renewed
1979	Symington Amendment – embargo over nuclear program (later abandoned due to Soviet invasion)
1981	\$3.2 billion military & economic assistance program
1986	\$4 billion second multi-year program
1990	Pressler Amendment terminated all aid
1990-1992	H.W. Bush allowed \$100 million private commercial sales
Clinton era	\$368 million released in lieu of defense assistance; sanctions after nuclear tests
Post-9/11	Paradigm shift – \$3 billion package (2005); designated major non-NATO ally
2005	US lifted arms sales embargo after 16-year hiatus; F-16 sales allowed
Bush administration	\$8.9 billion Coalition Support Fund disbursed by 2011
2009	Kerry-Lugar-Berman bill – \$1.5 billion non-military assistance annually for 5 years

May 2011	Osama bin Laden killed in Abbottabad – relations collapsed
2015	Overture for rapprochement – Obama agreed to 8 F-16s at subsidized rates
2016	US withdrew subsidy
Trump administration	Accused Pakistan of safe havens; cancelled \$300 million disbursement
Imran Khan era	Balanced approach; refused US bases for counterterrorism operations

Coalition Support Fund (CSF): Began reimbursing US allies for logistical/operational support of counterterrorism operations.

B. Relations with China (Sino-Pakistan Brotherhood)

Foundation:

- Pakistan recognized People's Republic of China in 1951
- All-weather partners – common Indian threat generated strong entente

Key Milestones:

Year	Event
1952	Barter agreement signed
1962	Sino-Pak border boundary agreement – removed territorial conflict

1963	Agreement for Xinjiang and adjacent areas
1967	China supplied machinery for Heavy Mechanical Complex, Taxila (15 million PKR) + interest-free loans
1970s	Joint ventures: Heavy Mechanical Complex, Heavy Ordnance Foundry, Aeronautical complex; military assistance \$630 million
1971	Pakistan instrumental in bringing US and China together – Nixon's historic trip to Beijing
1990 (Pressler)	Pakistan turned to China as more reliable ally
2008	China sold first A-100 Multiple Rocket Launcher units
2014	China exported \$394 million military weapons to Pakistan
2015	70% increase – \$565 million
2017	Contract for 4 Type-054 multi-role warships
2020	Inducted first batch of VT-4 battle tanks (Norinco); MoU for defense cooperation
2020 (Dec)	China to sell 50 Wing Loong II UCAVs
2021	HQ-9/P High to Medium Air Defence System integrated into Pakistan Army

JF-17 Thunder: Developed jointly by Chengdu Aircraft Corporation (China) and Pakistan Aeronautical Complex – exemplifies strong bonds. Has supplanted American F-16Cs as premier multirole fighter.

Shaheen Joint Military Exercises: Nine iterations – improve combat capacity and interoperability.

SIPRI Report (2016-2020): Pakistan remained main recipient of Chinese arms – 38% of Chinese arms exports.

Outstanding Orders (by 2028): 50 combat aircraft, 8 submarines, 4 frigates.

CPEC Dimension: China-Pakistan Economic Corridor – collection of infrastructure projects under Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). Runs from Kashgar (China's Xinjiang) to Gwadar Port (Balochistan).

C. Relations with Russia

Historical Trajectory:

Period	Status
Cold War	Fraught, mutual distrust, hostility
1950s	Pakistani air bases used for reconnaissance on Soviet Union
1960	U-2 incident further vitiated relations
Soviet support	To Afghanistan on "Pashtunistan" issue; to India on Kashmir

1965 war	US suspended arms supply – Soviet Union mediated Tashkent Conference (Jan 1966) – first major Soviet diplomatic venture in South Asia
1971	Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation (August); USSR supported India in 1971 war
1974	Z.A. Bhutto trip – Soviet economic investment in oil exploration & Steel Mills
1980s	Soviet invasion of Afghanistan – Pakistan's stewardship of anti-Soviet jihad reinforced antagonism
1990s	Fallout of Afghan War; Russia emerging from dissolution
Musharraf era	Cordial; Russia supported US-led war on terror
Post-Osama raid	US-Pak relations deteriorated
2011	Gen. Ashfaq Kayani convinced Russia to reconsider arms sales ban
2014 (Nov)	Comprehensive defense cooperation agreement signed (information exchange, counterterrorism, arms control, peacekeeping)

2017	Received 4 Mi-35M "Hind E" attack helicopters (\$153 million)
2017-2021	Druzhba I-VI joint military exercises
2018	Security Training Agreement (after US terminated IMET); Joint Military Commission formed

Joint Exercises:

- "Friendship" military exercises (2017)
- Arabian Monsoon naval drills (2014, 2015)
- Druzhba I-VI (2016-2021)
- Pakistan Navy-led AMAN exercise (45 countries including Russia)

Current Assessment:

- Relations still nascent but improving
- Pakistan's geographic allocation is political boon
- Both countries have fraught relationship with US – common ground
- Brazen India under Narendra Modi threatens Pakistan and peace in South Asia
- Room for better understanding of tactical, operational, and strategic thought

D. Relations with France

Historical Military Partnership:

Year	Event
1967	France sold first batch of Mirage fighters + submarine technology
1990	PAF bought second-hand Mirage jets

1994	Navy acquired Daphné class submarine + Agosta class technology transfer
1996	Contract for 40 reconnaissance aircraft
1973-1976	Three contracts for reprocessing plant (nuclear) – France backed out due to US pressure
2009	Nuclear deal agreed (confusion over scope – civilian tech vs. nuclear safety)
2011	France stopped all heavy military equipment sales to Pakistan to assuage Indian concerns

French Rationale (2011): After Osama bin Laden's death, Pakistan should explain position on terrorism – France did not want to be seen "feeding Pakistan's military ambitions."

E. Relations with Turkey

Historical Foundations:

- Relationship predates Pakistan's creation
- Muslims of Subcontinent supported Ottoman Empire and Khilafat
- Pakistanis admired Kemal Ataturk

Defense Cooperation:

Development	Details
CENTO members	Both members; founded ECO

Turkish arms transfer to Pakistan (2016-2019)	~\$112 million
Pakistan as Turkey's 3rd largest arms export market	Turkey as Pakistan's 4th largest arms source
Future acquisitions	4 MILGEM Ada-class corvettes; 30 T-129 Atak helicopters
2018	Pakistan Navy commissioned 17,000-ton fleet tanker from Turkish STM
STM contract	Upgrade Agosta 90B submarines (despite French pressure)
MILGEM project	4 corvettes for Pakistan Navy – 2 built in Turkey, 2 in Pakistan
2021	Turkey to buy 52 Super Mushshak aircraft from Pakistan
2021	Turkish Aerospace Inc set up office in Pakistan's National Science & Technology Park (radar, drones, cyber warfare)
2021	TAI & NESCOOM to jointly produce Turkish MALE Anka armed drone – technology transfer game-changer

Cultural Ties:

- Pakistani television airs Turkish dramas
- Both states support each other's narratives (Kashmir for Pakistan; Cyprus for Turkey)

F. Relations with Saudi Arabia

Foundation:

- Affectionate relationship from beginning
- Saudi Arabia is most important Muslim state because of Harmain Sharifain
- Every Saudi government pledged security & development of holy places

Defense Cooperation History:

Year	Event
1967	Defense cooperation formalized; dispatch of military/air force trainers
1969	Pakistani fighter pilots protected Kingdom from Yemeni incursions
1970s	Pakistani engineers built Saudi fortifications on Yemen border; soldiers stationed
1982	Protocol Agreement – "Deputation of Pakistani Armed Personnel & Military Training" – 15,000 troops deployed for Iran-Iraq War duration

Till 2016

Saudi Arabia was largest importer of Pakistani arms

2017

Pakistan member of Saudi-led Islamic Military Counter Terrorism Coalition (IMCTC)

Former Army Chief Gen. Raheel Sharif

Commands IMCTC

2018

Naseem Al Bahar XI joint naval exercise (PN & RSNF)

Al-Samsam military exercise

7 iterations (Pak Army & Saudi Royal Land Forces)

Aman-21

Saudi Arabia as observer

Nuclear Dimension:

- After Pakistan's first nuclear test, KSA was only state right behind Pakistan
- Pakistan promised security of KSA

Diplomatic Support:

- KSA always stood with Pakistan in every situation
- Trade relations of millions of dollars

VI. PAKISTAN'S RELATIONS WITH NEIGHBORS

A. Relations with India

Core Issues:

- Kashmir dispute (1948 war, UN resolutions, plebiscite refused by India)
- Division of assets (1947)
- River water distribution (Indus Waters Treaty)
- Line of Control (LoC) hotspot

Indo-Pakistan Wars & Limited Conflicts (1947-2025):

Type	Years
Wars	1947-48, 1965, 1971
Limited conflicts / crises	1984, 1999, 2001-02, 2016, 2019, 2025 (hybrid conflict)

Note: 2025 is not a declared war but correctly included as limited/hybrid conflict.

Pakistan's Position:

- India's hegemonic aspirations threaten Pakistan and peace in South Asia
- India under Narendra Modi considered particularly brazen
- India has built bridges with Iran, China, Afghanistan, Tajikistan, UAE in Pakistan's vicinity
- India formed "India, Brazil, South Africa Dialogue Forum" (IBSA) to expand diplomatic leverage

B. Relations with Afghanistan

Historical Context:

- Pitfall relationship since beginning
- Durand Line border agreement (1893 between British Empire and Nazim-e-Ala of Afghanistan)
- Afghanistan claims agreement expired; demands Makran and Torkham for sea access
- Afghanistan was only country to object to Pakistan's UN membership

Key Events:

Period	Event
1965 & 1971 wars	Afghanistan remained neutral
Soviet invasion	Pakistan supported Afghanistan internationally; opened border for refugees; assisted Mujahideen
1988	USSR and Afghanistan signed treaty in Geneva – Pakistan, Russia, America parties
Post-Soviet	Taliban took over – Pakistan recognized Taliban government
Post-9/11	US attacked Afghanistan; Pakistan opened border again for refugees; faced terrorist attacks
Recent	Pakistan recognized first elected government; played role in US-Afghanistan peace agreement
Current	Looking forward to developing cordial relationship with new Afghan Taliban government

Pakistan's Role:

- Accommodated millions of Afghan refugees for decades
- Suffered terrorist attacks due to war on terror
- Still plays mediator role

C. Relations with Iran

Foundation:

- Iran was one of first states to recognize Pakistan
- Shah of Iran was first head of state to visit Pakistan after its separation

Historical Trajectory:

- Both members of many international/regional organizations
- Continued cordial relationship even after 1979 revolution (USA sanctioned Iran, Pakistan was Western bloc member)
- Majority populations belong to different sects but connected
- Both neighboring states of Afghanistan – same page on Taliban and war on terror
- Both opened borders for Afghan refugees; face same problems

Current Cooperation (Under President Ebrahim Raisi):

- Iran wants revival of JCPOA, regional role, relations with Saudi Arabia, stance on Israel
- Pakistan can bridge Iran and Saudi Arabia

Bilateral Trade:

- \$359 million currently
- Steps to increase: Free Trade Agreement (FTA), border markets, banking channels, elimination of illegal trade, business delegations, joint trade exhibitions

Energy & Infrastructure:

- Iran signed agreement similar to CPEC with China
- Iran shown interest to join CPEC
- Iran provides electricity to Balochistan regions (Gwadar, Turbat, Makran) – currently 100 megawatts, can increase to 3000 megawatts
- Need to resolve technical problems

Border Security:

- 928 km border – cooperation to stop illegal trade, narcotics, terrorism

D. Relations with Bangladesh

Historical Context:

- East Pakistan separated on December 16, 1971
- West Pakistan renamed Islamic Republic of Pakistan

Improvement:

- During Benazir Bhutto's first term, relations began to improve
- Mian Nawaz Sharif's incomplete reigns hindered progress
- 1999: President Pervez Musharraf visited Bangladesh – discussed eradicating painful memories, resolving past mistakes

Current Status:

- Relations improving but still lack warmth expected between Muslim brothers
- Signed several agreements: science, education, culture, agriculture

E. Relations with Central Asian Republics (5 Muslim States)

States: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan (Kyrgyz Republic), Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan

Geographic Fact: Distance between Tajikistan and Pakistan is only 16 km (Wakkhan Border)

History:

- After Soviet disintegration, Pakistan fully supported Central Asia
- Included these states in Economic Cooperation Organization (ECO) in 1992
- Signed many MOUs of cooperation
- Part of pipeline projects (e.g., TAPI)
- People-to-people relationships

VII. PAKISTAN'S RELATIONS WITH THE MUSLIM WORLD

A. The Muslim World: Significance

Geography & Demographics:

- Spread from Indonesia to Morocco – 4 continents (Africa, Asia, Australia, Europe)
- Every fourth person in world is Muslim
- More than 50 states around Mediterranean Sea, oceans of Africa and Asia
- Many Middle Eastern and Central Asian states rich in oil, gas, coal

Challenges in Muslim World:

- Total trade:
- 110 billion globally;
- 110 billion globally; 14 billion within Islamic World
- Muslim states spend only 0.5% of GDP on education
- Non-Muslim states suppress Muslims (Afghanistan, Palestine, Kashmir, Rohingya, Syria, Yemen, Chechnya)
- Verbal unity only – not practical
- Corruption and incompetent political leadership
- Sectarian divisions and different interpretations of Islamic law

Resources Available: Sufficient defensive technology and resources – but focus on peaceful methods.

B. Pakistan's Role & Leadership in Muslim World

Constitutional Basis: Article 40 (already detailed)

Demographic Fact: 96%+ Muslim population; Islam as state religion

Historical Efforts:

- Before Pakistan's creation, Muslim leaders of Subcontinent supported Ottoman Empire and raised funds
- Muslim brotherhood is in Pakistan's DNA

Nuclear Dimension:

- Pakistan is only Muslim nuclear state
- Nukes known as "Islamic Bomb"
- Zulfikar Ali Bhutto gave "Islamic Bomb" idea in 1978 speeches
- General Zia-ul-Haq: "If Pakistan creates its own nukes, it boosts up power of Muslim states worldwide"

- Pakistan received support of Islamic world for collective deterrence or "Islamic Deterrence"

Pakistan's Continuous Role:

- Bridges between Shia and Sunni states
- Prime Ministers always speak for Kashmir and Palestine at UN and other forums
- Supports verbally and as mediator; hosts meetings; Pakistani people give funds for Muslim brothers

Quaid-e-Azam on Palestine (1945 & after becoming Governor-General):

- "I have no enmity against the Jews...But why should the Arabs be dumped with such a large number of Jews?"
- Sent message to President Truman questioning partition of Palestine

Pakistan's Support for Muslim Causes:

- Independence of Indonesia, Libya, Morocco, Sudan, Tunisia, former colonies
- Palestine, Syria, Chechnya, Rohingya, Kashmir, Sudan
- 1973 Arab-Israel war – supported Arab Alliance; Pakistani pilots fought Israeli jets in aerial combat
- 1979 Soviet invasion of Afghanistan – supported Mujahideen; opened border for millions of refugees
- 1990 – opened border for Bosnian refugees after Yugoslavia breakup
- Supports Muslims of Herzegovina and Kosovo
- Pakistani soldiers in UN peacekeeping missions
- Does not recognize Israel

C. Bilateral Relations with Key Muslim Countries

Saudi Arabia

(Detailed in Section V-F above)

Turkey

(Detailed in Section V-E above)

Iran

(Detailed in Section VI-C above)

Afghanistan

(Detailed in Section VI-B above)

Bangladesh

(Detailed in Section VI-D above)

Egypt

Context:

- Both important states on different continents – connected by religion, culture, brotherhood
- Cold War setbacks: Egypt followed Non-Alignment Movement (NAM); Pakistan was in West bloc (SEATO, CENTO)
- Post-Cold War: Both trying to develop relationship

Recent Developments:

- 48th conference of OIC's CFM – both states came close
- Foreign Minister Shah Mahmood Qureshi: "We want to re-engage with Egypt to enhance economic diplomacy"
- Current annual trade with Africa: \$4 billion – Egypt can help Pakistan enter North African markets
- President Al Sisi invited to visit Pakistan – accepted

Libya

Historical Relationship:

- Friendly, bilateral since Pakistan's independence
- 1970: Libya gave millions in loans/aid after Bangladesh separation
- Z.A. Bhutto and General Ghaddafi had very close relationship in 1970s
- Signed agreement on economic and cultural relations
- Mutual assistance against floods, infection, disease, natural catastrophes

People-to-People:

- ~30,000 Pakistanis living in Libya
- 2009: Pakistan guaranteed to send >50,000 skilled workers, carpenters, masons, electricians, steel fixers, plumbers, engineers, architects, doctors, teachers

Agreements (2009):

- Extradition agreement
- MOUs on Labour & Manpower, Higher Education, Human Resource Development, Political Consultations, Culture & Information, Abolition of Diplomatic Visas

Trade:

- Pakistan exports: textile, engineering, food, leather products
- Pakistan imports: chemical material, plastic material, other instruments, appliances

Post-Arab Spring:

- Relationship faced hurdles but now rebuilding
- Pakistan assisting in reconstruction and rebuilding
- Export of human resources to Libya increasing again

United Arab Emirates (UAE)

Foundation:

- Pakistan was first state to recognize UAE in 1972 (right after independence)
- Sheikh Zayed considered Pakistan his second home

People-to-People:

- Hundreds of thousands of Pakistanis working in UAE productions
- Workforce assisted UAE in infrastructure, economy, regional security

UAE Support to Pakistan:

- Financial support and investment in mega projects (bridges, hospitals, airports)
- Sheikh Zaid Hospital example

Aviation Cooperation:

- 1985: PIA helped UAE establish "Emirates" airline – technical/administrative assistance, consultancy, leased two aircraft
- Emirates selected Karachi as first international destination (token of appreciation)

Indonesia

Foundation:

- World's largest Muslim population (Pakistan #2)
- Treaty of Friendship signed March 3, 1951 in Jakarta
- Islamic unity as basis for friendship

Economic Relations:

- Both members of ASEAN
- President Joko Widodo visited Pakistan in 2018 – signed more MOUs
- Preferential Trade Agreement (2013) implemented
- 2020 trade: \$2.6 billion

Pakistan exports: Cotton, raw hides and skin, semi-finished iron, rice, citrus

Pakistan imports: Palm oil (largest), coal, artificial staple filaments, paper, betel nuts, elastic, cleanser preparations, tea, chemical items, organic synthetic chemicals, motor vehicles

Academic Cooperation:

- ~1000 Pakistani students studying in 23 Indonesian Universities
- Fields: Entomology, Microbiology, Pharmacy, Biology, Biomedical Engineering, Clinical Pharmacy, Information Technology, Psychology, Electrical Engineering, Informatics, Computer Engineering

Other Muslim World Engagements

Azerbaijan: Pakistan does not recognize Armenia (illegal occupation of Nagorno-Karabakh). Azerbaijan supports Pakistan on Kashmir.

OIC: Pakistan organized second OIC Summit in Lahore (1974). Consistently works for Islamic unity.

Central Asian Republics: (Detailed in Section VI-E)

Pakistan's Support for Muslims Worldwide: Rohingya, Yemen, Syria, Chechnya, Bosnia, Kosovo, Palestine.

VIII. PAKISTAN AND REGIONAL ORGANIZATIONS

A. Economic Cooperation Organization (ECO)

- Founded by Pakistan, Iran, Turkey
- Central Asian states included in 1992

B. Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO)

- Russia endorsed Pakistan's bid
- Pakistan's addition widens strategic options given conflictual US relationship
- Particularly important after Taliban takeover (2021)

C. Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)

- Pakistan hosted 2nd Summit (Lahore, 1974)
- Hosted 48th Conference of CFM recently
- Pakistan consistently works for Islamic unity

D. SEATO & CENTO (Historical)

- Joined 1954 & 1955; later withdrew
- Legacies of Cold War

E. Non-Alignment Movement (NAM)

- Joined 1979 (Havana Summit)
-

IX. CHINA-PAKISTAN ECONOMIC CORRIDOR (CPEC)

A. What is CPEC?

A collection of infrastructure projects forming part of China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).

Route: Runs from Kashgar (China's Xinjiang province) to Gwadar Port (Pakistan's Balochistan)

B. Geographic Significance for Pakistan

Feature	Significance
North-South Connectivity	Creates logistical spine connecting China to Arabian Sea
Gwadar Port	Deep-water port strategically located near Strait of Hormuz (global oil chokepoint) – centerpiece of CPEC
Karakoram Highway	One of world's highest paved roads, traversing Gilgit-Baltistan – shows rugged geography harnessed for connectivity
Strategic Centrality	Positions Pakistan as trade and energy corridor between Middle East, Central Asia, China, and global maritime routes

C. Economic Significance

- Enhances Pakistan's infrastructure and energy sectors
- Increases Pakistan's geopolitical value for China and wider BRI
- Creates employment opportunities
- Absorbs talented youth
- Enhances national integration (if handled pragmatically)

D. Iran's Interest in CPEC

- Iran signed agreement similar to CPEC with China
- Iran shown interest to join CPEC to expand trade ties with Pakistan

X. CHALLENGES FACED BY PAKISTAN'S FOREIGN POLICY

A. Security Concerns

- Eastern border with India (LoC hotspot)
- Western border with Afghanistan (porous, mountainous)
- Terrorism spillover from Afghanistan (two decades of War on Terror)
- Great power rivalry and geopolitical rivalry in region

B. Internal Challenges Affecting Foreign Policy

- Political instability
- Economic constraints (defense modernization burden on fledgling economy)
- Lack of national consensus on foreign policy issues
- Quality of leadership
- Weak domestic base

C. Post-Cold War Challenges

- Isolation after cold war ended
- Pressured to roll back nuclear programme
- Threatened with terrorist tag

- Silenced on Kashmir
- Abandoned in Afghanistan
- Viewed with suspicion in Arab/Islamic world

D. Implementation & Structural Gaps

- "Traditional diplomacy" insufficient
- Relations with distant godfathers no substitute for regional bonds
- Need to expand indigenous defense industrial base
- Absent strategic transformation of economy, Pakistan cannot establish strategic defense relations

E. Regional Challenges

- India's hegemonic aspirations
- India's broadened diplomatic reach (IBSA, ties with Iran, China, Afghanistan, Tajikistan, UAE)
- Afghanistan instability
- Iran balancing act

XI. OPPORTUNITIES AND BENEFITS OF PAKISTAN'S STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

1. China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) – economic lifeline
2. Regional Connectivity – trade and energy corridor potential
3. Counterterrorism Cooperation – value as frontline state
4. Diplomacy and Reconciliation – role in Afghanistan, role in Muslim world
5. Agricultural Significance – Indus River System
6. Cultural and Historical Crossroads – soft power potential
7. Nuclear Capability – only Muslim nuclear state; "Islamic bomb" as leadership tool
8. SCO Membership – widened strategic options
9. Growing Russia Relations – alternate defense supplier
10. Turkey Defense Cooperation – technology transfer, joint production

XII. CONCLUSION: SYNTHESIS & FUTURE PATHWAYS

A. Key Lessons from Historical Phases

1. Neutrality (1947-53): Initial non-alignment was forced by internal weakness, not strategic choice.
2. Alliances (1954-62): Cost more than gain – earned ill will without achieving Kashmir objective.
3. Bilateralism (1963-78): Equidistance from superpowers opened new friendships (China, Muslim world).
4. Non-Alignment (1979-89): NAM membership combined with US partnership – pragmatism over ideology.
5. Post-Cold War (1990-2001): Lost time adjusting – isolation and pressure.
6. Anti-Terrorism (2001-present): Frontline role earned appreciation but at enormous human and economic cost (\$150 billion+).

B. Core Realities for Pakistan's Foreign Policy

- Domestic base is everything: Political stability, national consensus, sound economy, effective deterrence, quality of leadership.
- Regional bonds > distant godfathers: Relations with US no substitute for good relations with neighbors (Iran, Afghanistan, China, India).
- Skillful diplomacy matters: Traditional diplomacy insufficient – need innovation and novel means.
- Economic capacity is foundation: Defense procurements and ability to become defense supplier hinge on economic capacity.
- Indigenous defense industrial base must be expanded.

C. Way Forward

1. Prioritize geoeconomics over geostrategy (as reflected in NSP 2022-2026)
2. Broaden framework of national security beyond military concerns
3. Leverage economic and military diplomacy to become reliable defense partner

4. Avoid catch-up with India – focus on Pakistan's own national interests
5. Build strategic relations with multiple powers (China, Russia, Turkey, US tactically)
6. Lead Muslim world through diplomacy, not domination
7. Strengthen regional connectivity (CPEC, TAPI, ECO, SCO)
8. Maintain nuclear deterrence while engaging diplomatically
9. Resolve internal political polarization to present united front externally
10. Keep Kashmir and Palestine on international agenda consistently

D. Final Assessment

Pakistan's defense and foreign relations with major powers show a great deal of pragmatic maneuvering, with a view to achieving its national interests in a sea of partisanship, regional alliances, and diplomatic chicanery.

Absent a strategic transformation of its economy, Pakistan would not be able to establish defense relations of a strategic nature, and, in the process, lose a chance to influence major powers.

Pakistan's focus on broadening the framework of national security and leveraging its geoeconomic power augurs well for the future.